Bluebook Studying & Exam Strategies

Monday, February 16, 2026

Admissions Updates

February 18 – Big Day!

- DE Office Hours, 4-5 pm, SLB Dining Hall
- **Practice Critical Essay** Due at 5:00 pm
  - Note on Student ID Number (9-digit number on bottom left of ID)
- Sourcecite **Exam Conflict Form** Due at 11:59 pm
- Reach out to SAS for **Sourcecite Exam Accommodations** by 11:59 pm

Admissions Events!

- **Inside the First Year**: Perspectives from Upper Masthead on Tuesday, **February 24**, 12:10 pm
- **Inside Upper Masthead**: Student Perspectives on Thursday, **February 26**, 2:10 pm

Exam Overview

Overview

- **Exam Date: March 28-29**
- **Exam Length: 3.5 hours**
- **Permitted Resources**: Online and Hardcopy *Bluebook*, Volume 136 Style Guide, *Bluebook* Correction Sheet, Hyphenation Guide, *YLJ* Admissions SharePoint Resources, Merriam-Webster Dictionary, Chicago Manual of Style, Personal Outlines/Cheat-Sheets
  - **Disallowed**: Additional Internet Sources, Assistance from Other Individuals, ChatGPT, Grammarly, and other AI Tools
- **Exam Materials**: Exam Document, Source Packet

In 2014, when the Supreme Court decided Bond v. United States, it confronted an isssue of structural federalism that had long vexed advocates of big and small government alike.[1] The issue stemmed from the tension between the exclusive power of the Federal Government to conclude international treaties with congress's limited domestic authority vis-à-vis the states[2]. When these powers and limitations conflict, which should win out? For both champions and critics of International Law, the Court's response in Bond left much to be desired.[3]

Admittedly, Bond offered the court an unlikely set of facts through which to clarify the scope of the Treaty Power. After petitioner Carol Ann Bond was caught attempting to inflict chemical

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1. 134 S.Ct. 2077 (2000). Other cases have raised related issues. *See, e.g.*, James De Geofroy v. Jesse M. Riggs, Jr., 133 U.S. 258, 267 (1890); Smith v. Peterson, 767 F. Supp. 654, 671 (7th Cir. 2014) (Wood, C.J., dissent) (same); United States v. Schimel, 863 F.2d 674, 711 (5th Cir. 1981) (same); Sanchez v. Davidson Bros., Co., 412 F.2d 227 (2nd Cir. 1972) (same).
2. *See* U.S. Const. amendment X. The court last addressed this tension in Missouri v. Holland, 252 U.S. 416 (1812). For historical discussions, *see* Curtis A. Bradley, *The Treaty Power and American Federalism*, 97 MI. L. REV. 390, 409-33 (1998); David M. Golove, *Treaty-Making and the Nation: The Historical Foundations of the Nationalist Conception of the Treaty Power*, 98 MI. L. REV. 1275, 1257-69 (2000); Oona A. Hathaway et al., *The Treaty Power: Its History, Scope, and Limits*, 98 CORN. L. REV. 239, 279-304 (2013); Nicholas Quinn Rosenkranz, *Executing the Treaty Power*, 118 HARV. L. REV. 1867 (2005); Edward T. Swaine, *Does Federalism Constrain the Treaty Power*, 103 COLUMBIA L. REV; & Felix Vincent, Interpreting the Treaty Power, BROOKINGS INSTITUTE (Apr. 10, 2013),

Example Exam

The *Bluebook* Exam mirrors the practice exercises. Historically, they have been 8-9 pages long. You will take the exam in Microsoft Word. As a reminder, you will not be tested on the Blue Pages.

Point Distribution

1 point	2 points
• Correcting *Bluebook* formatting errors	• Correcting errors from the source packet • Flagging logical errors
0 points	**-1 point**
• Failing to correct objective errors • Making unnecessary stylistic or subjective changes (word choice/sentence structure)	• *Introducing* an objective error into a correctly formatted citation

There are hundreds of errors on the exam. You are not expected to find them all.

Skills for the Exam

The Sourcecite Exam is about accuracy and speed. Not pure memorization.

You are expected to look things up during the exam.

While it is helpful to memorize some rules, a lot of that happen naturally as you practice. Key point is knowing there's a rule for something and knowing where to find it.

Debunking Inaccurate Info

Myth: There is a big gap between the Sourcecite Exam scores that will get someone onto *YLJ* and those that won't. So long as you try hard, you're guaranteed to get on.

Debunking Inaccurate Info

~~**Myth:** There is a big gap between the Sourcecite Exam scores that will get someone onto *YLJ* and those that won't. So long as you try hard, you're guaranteed to get on.~~

Fact: The difference between Sourcecite Exam scores for applicants who do and do not get on *YLJ* can sometimes differ by only a few points. Plenty of people try hard on the application process and do not get onto *YLJ*. Although time commitment is often a primary factor in this outcome, finding efficient study strategies that work for your learning style is a key to success.

Gaining Familiarity with the *Bluebook*

Overview

At over 300 pages, mastering the *Bluebook* can feel daunting. A lot of students find it helpful to engage with resources that help them gain familiarity with the different sections of the *Bluebook* before tackling the practice exercises.

- **Common Resources**: Hard copy and online versions of the *Bluebook*, *Bluebook* guides, *YLJ Bluebook* Presentations

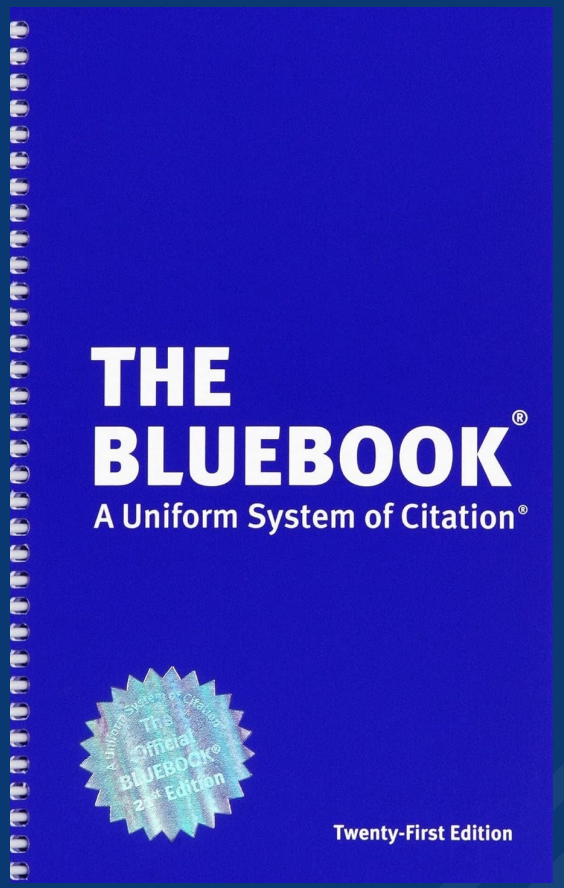
Reading the *Bluebook*: Pros & Cons

Pros

- Learn how the *Bluebook* is structured and what it contains

Cons:

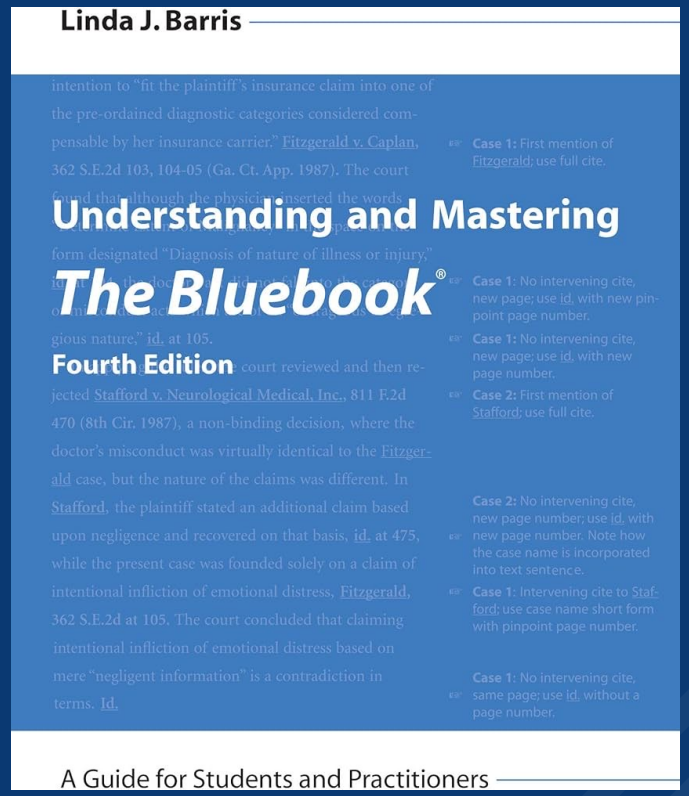
- Time consuming
- Can't practice application
- Under- and Overinclusive
  - Need to learn the Style Guide and Hyphenation Guide
  - *YLJ* deprioritizes certain sections



If using this method, read the Style Guide as you go along to ensure you are learning the correct rules.

Bluebook Primers: Pros & Cons

Some students like to gain familiarity with the *Bluebook* by reading primers or summary guides.



Pros

- Learn key points about the *Bluebook*
- Faster than reading the *Bluebook* in its entirety

Cons:

- Time consuming (i.e., this guide is still 200 pages)
- Can't practice application
- Under- and Overinclusive
  - Need to learn the Style Guide and Hyphenation Guide
  - YLJ deprioritizes certain sections

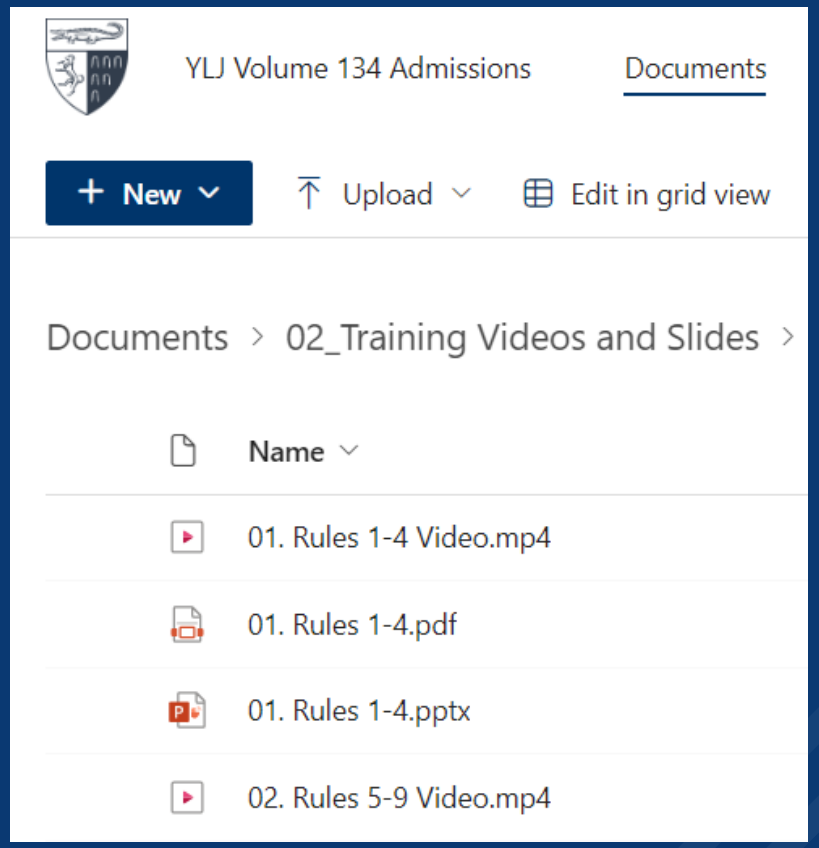
YLJ Presentations: Pros & Cons

Pros

- Efficient
- Learn how the *Bluebook* is structured
- Understand which rules *YLJ* prioritizes
- Incorporates the Style Guide
- Includes practice exercises

Cons:

- Doesn't cover every part of the *Bluebook* that you need to know



Can choose between attending in person, watching the videos, or reading the slides

Updating Your *Bluebook*

Update your *Bluebook* as you go through the process of familiarizing yourself with its structure and content

1. Tab your *Bluebook*
2. Write in *Bluebook* Corrections in **Red**
3. Add changes from the Style Guide

Reading the Hyphenation Guide

The goal is not to memorize the hyphenation guide, but rather to understand general rules and exceptions.

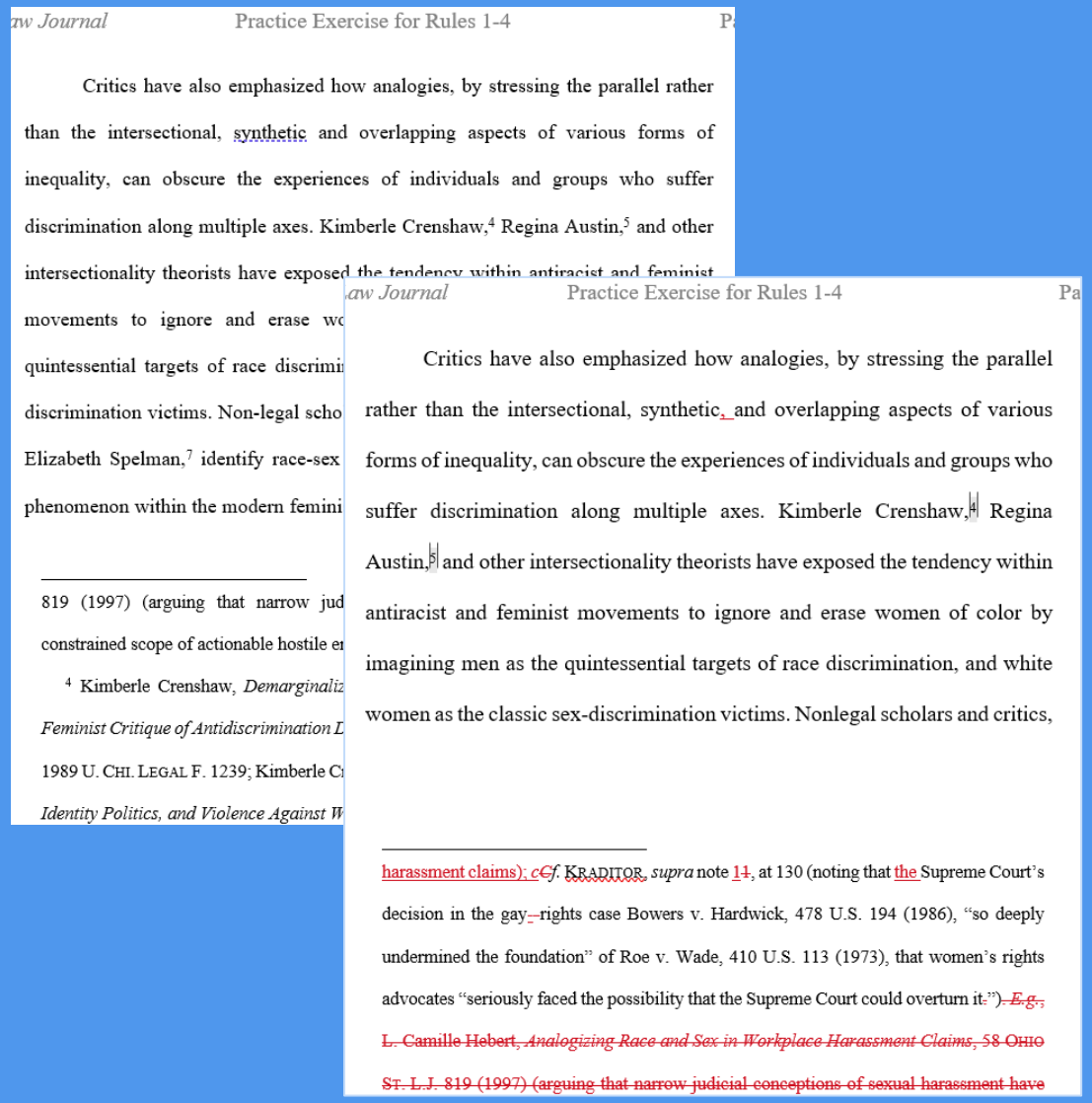
- E.g., if two words describe a subsequent noun, they are generally hyphenated (lime-green tie, high-ranking official, near-term proposal)
- Exceptions include, but are not limited to
  - Adverbs ending in –ly are not hyphenated
  - Decision-making is always hyphenated

Category/specific term	*Examples*	*Summary of rule*
2. COMPOUNDS ACCORDING TO PARTS OF SPEECH (continued)		
noun + gerund	*decision making* a *decision-making* body *mountain climbing* *time-clock-punching* employees a *Nobel Prize–winning* chemist (see 6.80) *bookkeeping* *caregiving* *copyediting*	Noun form usually open; adjective form hyphenated before a noun. Some permanent compounds closed (see 7.78).
noun + noun, single function (first noun modifies second noun)	*student nurse* *restaurant owner* *directory path* *tenure track* *tenure-track* position *home-rule* governance *shipbuilder* *gunrunner* *copyeditor*	Noun form open; adjective form hyphenated before a noun. Some permanent compounds closed (see 7.78).
noun + noun, two functions (both nouns equal)	*nurse-practitioner* *philosopher-king* *city-state* *city-state* governance	Both noun and adjective forms always hyphenated.
noun + numeral or enumerator	*type A* a *type A* executive *type 2* diabetes *size 12* slacks a *page 1* headline	Both noun and adjective forms always open.
noun + participle	a *Wagner-burdened* repertoire *flower-filled* garden a *clothes-buying* grandmother a day of *clothes buying*	Hyphenated before a noun, otherwise open.
participle + noun	*chopped-liver* pâté *cutting-edge* methods their approach was *cutting edge*	Adjective form hyphenated before but not after a noun.
participle + up, out, and similar adverbs	*dressed-up* children *burned-out* buildings *ironed-on* decal we were *dressed up* that decal is *ironed on*	Adjective form hyphenated before but not after a noun. Verb form always open.

Engaging with Practice Exercises

Overview

- There is at least one full practice exercise and answer key for each training (e.g., Rules 1-4, Rules 5-9, etc.)
  - Each exercise has a corresponding answer key
- While there are other *Bluebook* practice problems available online, we caution against them because they do not incorporate the Style Guide



aw Journal Practice Exercise for Rules 1-4 Pa

Critics have also emphasized how analogies, by stressing the parallel rather than the intersectional, synthetic, and overlapping aspects of various forms of inequality, can obscure the experiences of individuals and groups who suffer discrimination along multiple axes. Kimberle Crenshaw,[4] Regina Austin,[5] and other intersectionality theorists have exposed the tendency within antiracist and feminist movements to ignore and erase women of color by imagining men as the quintessential targets of race discrimination, and white women as the classic sex-discrimination victims. Nonlegal scholars and critics,

harassment claims); c~~C~~f. KRADITOR, *supra* note 1~~1~~, at 130 (noting that the Supreme Court's decision in the gay–rights case Bowers v. Hardwick, 478 U.S. 194 (1986), "so deeply undermined the foundation" of Roe v. Wade, 410 U.S. 113 (1973), that women's rights advocates "seriously faced the possibility that the Supreme Court could overturn it.")~~. E.g., L. Camille Hebert, *Analogizing Race and Sex in Workplace Harassment Claims*, 58 OHIO ST. L.J. 819 (1997) (arguing that narrow judicial conceptions of sexual harassment have~~

Steps to Doing a Practice Exercise

1. Review the rules, trainings, slides, etc.
2. Do the practice exercise
3. Check the answer key
4. Write down the list of errors you didn't catch
5. Read the corresponding *Bluebook* or Style Guide rules for any error that you are especially confused about
6. Move on to the next exercise
   - Wouldn't recommend repeating an exercise until you get 100%. Will make that exercise less useful when you repeat it.
7. Go back to the first practice exercise and repeat steps 1-6

Learning from Mistakes

By writing down mistakes after doing every practice exercise, you'll learn which rules are unintuitive for you and where you should focus your attention.

In addition to rereading these rules, consider highlighting them in your *Bluebook*.

These rules are also good candidates for your Exam Checklist.

For the hardest rules, we recommend adding additional tabs to the bottom of your *Bluebook* or pinning the Rules in the online version.

Exam Checklists

Checklists consist of two types of rules: 1) rules you miss most frequently and 2) rules you want to Ctrl+F for on the exam.

Consider whether you want a digital or paper Checklist.

The YLW+ Outline Bank has numerous *Bluebook* outlines and checklists to get inspiration from. It's most helpful to make one yourself, so that it's tailored to your individual needs.

Example Checklist Items

Helpful Checklist Items	
Cf., but cf. see also, see generally (explanatory parenthetical)	Emphasis in original (delete)
"Statues" vs. Statutes	Article/Note/Comment (capitalized)
1981 (5th / 11th Circuit split)	Part/Section (capitalized when self-reference)
26 U.S.C. ⟶ I.R.C.	2nd ⟶ 2d
Et al. (remove for cases/authors)	3rd ⟶ 3d
Last updated (delete)	Last visited (delete)

Speed Considerations

Overview

- There are hundreds of errors on the Sourcecite Exam. We are not expecting you to find all of them in the 3.5 hours allotted.
- The goal is to fix as many errors as possible.
  - Don’t sacrifice accuracy for speed! Remember, inserting errors will cause you to lose points.
- If you aren’t sure about an error and think it will take you a long time to solve it, consider noting it and moving on.
  - Come back to it if you have time at the end.

Track Changes Visible vs. Hidden

~~168~~-Jay M. Hill, *Women of Color Taking on the Constitution: Pauli Murray a*

C.R.-C.L. L. REV.~~EV.~~ 265, 259-70 (1998); *cf.* Hannah Arendt, *On Revo*

~~169~~168 J. ~~LEG~~LEGIS. HIST~~IST~~. 678, 679 (<year>) (referring to Jjustice Br

Oregon, <case citation>).

~~171~~169 No states ratified the ERA after 1977, but~~,~~ several came very close

June 1982. JANE J. MANSBRIDGE, WHY WE LOST THE ERA~~HY WE LOST~~

of the ERA's defeat, see MARY FRANCES BERRY, WHY ERA FAILED~~ARY F~~

<pincite> (1986); and MANSBRIDGE~~ANSBRIDGE~~, *supra*, at <pincite>.

456 F. Supp. 265, 245 ~~(1990)~~ (D.-N.J. 1990) ~~(recounting the history o~~

J., dissenting) (recounting the history of the ERA)s.

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168 Jay M. Hill, *Women of Color Taking on the*

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169 No states ratified the ERA after 1977, but

June 1982. JANE J. MANSBRIDGE, WHY WE L

MARY FRANCES BERRY, WHY ERA FAILED <p

Weinstein v. Bluebell, 456 F. Supp. 265, 245

of the ERA).

Track Changes Visible

Pros

- Can tell what you've already fixed
- Easier to pick up where you left off

Cons:

- More likely to introduce small errors (e.g., extra spaces, additional periods)
- Need to build in additional review time
- May slow down your computer

~~168~~-Jay M. Hill, *Women of Color Taking on the Constitution: Pauli Murray and the R~~r~~ace-Gender Pioneers*, 9 HARV.~~ARV~~. C.R.-C.L. L. REV.~~EV.~~ 265, 259-70 (1998); *cf.* Hannah Arendt, *On Revolution*, 71

~~169~~168 J. ~~LEG~~LEGIS. HIST~~IST~~. 678, 679 (<year>) (referring to J~~j~~ustice Brewer's opinions of women in Muller v. Oregon, <case citation>).

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Track Changes Hidden

Pros

- Easier to catch small errors (e.g., punctuation, spaces)
- Won't slow down computer
- Less need to review your work

Cons:

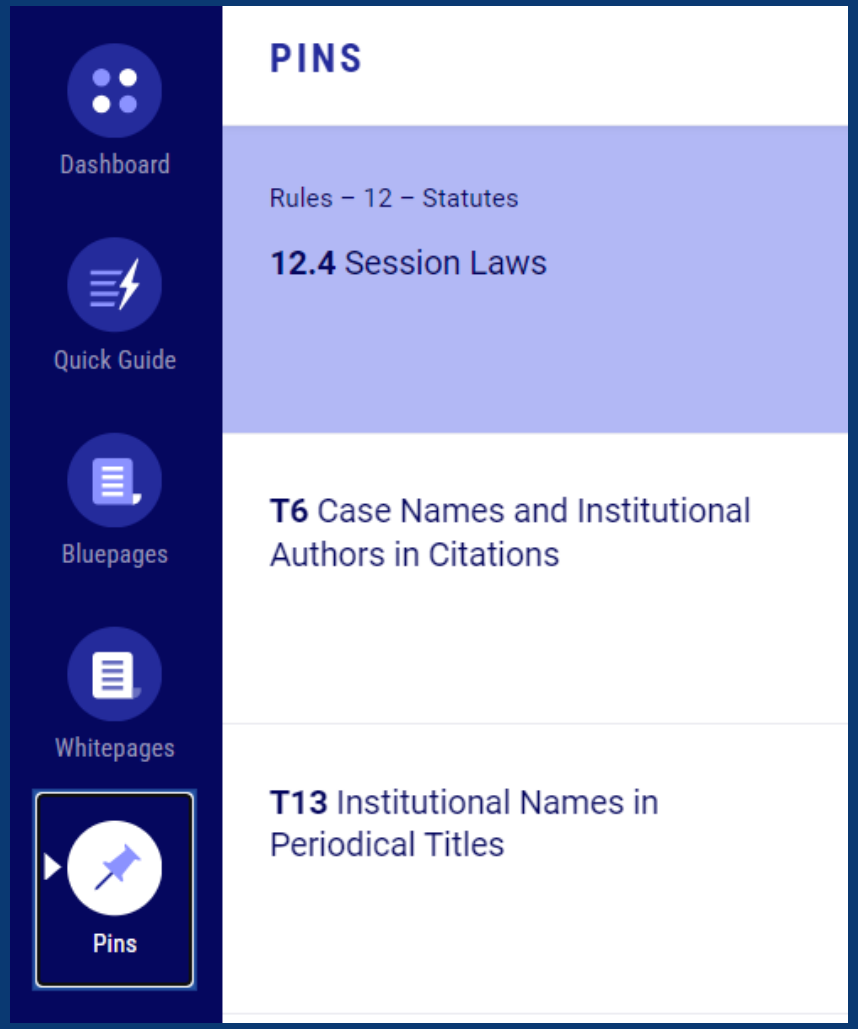
- Harder to tell what you last checked

[168] Jay M. Hill, *Women of Color Taking on the Constitution: Pauli Murray and the Race-Gender Pioneers*, 9 HARV.. C.R.-C.L. L. REV. 265, 259-70 (1998); *cf.* Hannah Arendt, *On Revolution*, 71 J. LEGIS. HIST. 678, 679 (<year>) (referring to Justice Brewer's opinions of women in Muller v. Oregon, <case citation>).

[169] No states ratified the ERA after 1977, but several came very close before the ratification period expired in June 1982. JANE J. MANSBRIDGE, WHY WE LOST THE ERA 184 (1986). For analyses of the ERA's defeat, see MARY FRANCES BERRY, WHY ERA FAILED <pincite> (1986); and MANSBRIDGE, *supra*, at <pincite>. *See also* Weinstein v. Bluebell, 456 F. Supp. 265, 245 (D.N.J. 1990) (Winfield, J., dissenting) (recounting the history

Pinning Bluebook Rules

- Pinning *Bluebook* rules gives you easy access to the rules you use more often.
- Depending on what you're looking for, it can be easier to navigate to a "pinned" rule than it is to search the *Bluebook* as a whole.
- Click the pin button on the bottom right of the *Bluebook* page to add a new rule to your pin list.



Navigation Shortcuts

Navigation Shortcuts		
Function	**PC**	**Mac**
Switch Apps/Windows	Alt+Tab	Cmd+Tab
Move Chrome Tabs Right	Ctrl+Tab	Cmd+Opt+Right Arrow
Move Chrome Tabs Left	Ctrl+Shift+Tab	Cmd+Opt+Left Arrow
Search	Ctrl+F	Cmd+F

These shortcuts are NOT necessary but can be incredibly helpful on the exam and beyond.

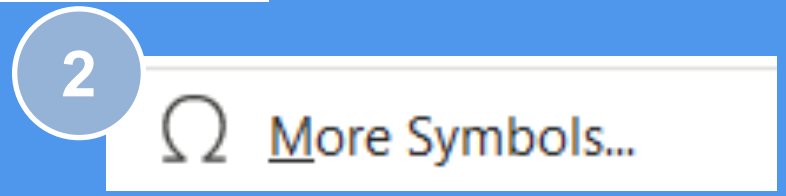
Bluebook Shortcuts

Bluebook Shortcuts		
Function	PC	Mac
Italicize	Ctrl+I	Cmd+I
Nonbreaking Space	Ctrl+Shift+Space	Opt+Space
Check Spacing	Ctrl+Shift+8	Cmd+8
Small Caps	Ctrl+Shift+K	Cmd+Shift+K
Highlight (marking tool)	Ctrl+Shift+Alt	Cmd+Shift+H
§	Map Keys	Opt+6
¶	Map Keys	Opt+7
Em dash (—)	Map Keys	Opt+Shift+Dash(-)

These shortcuts are NOT necessary but can be incredibly helpful on the exam and beyond.

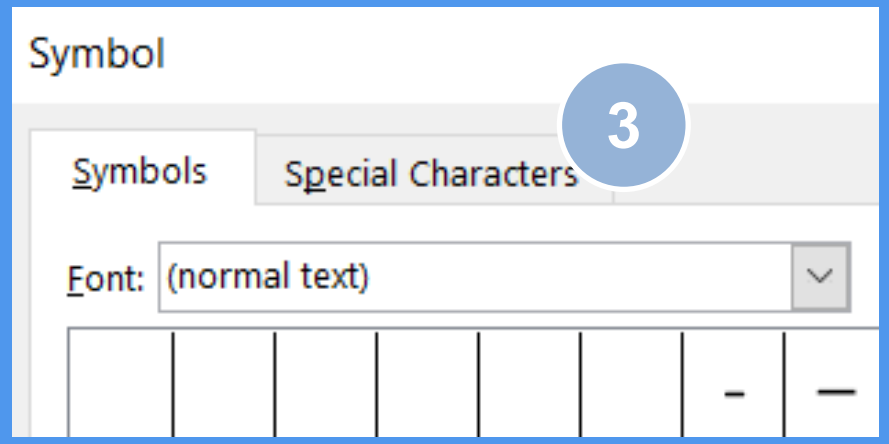
Mapping Symbols to Keys

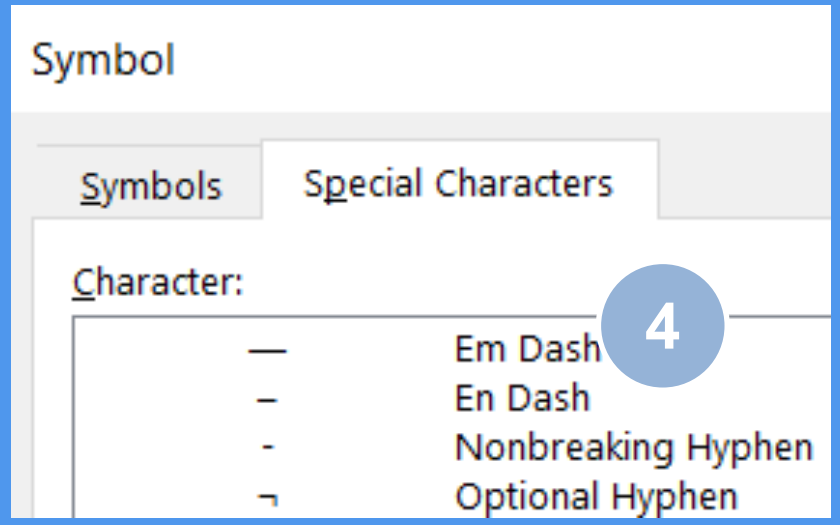
1. Navigate to “Insert” and click “Symbol”
2. Click “More Symbols” in the dropdown



Mapping Symbols to Keys

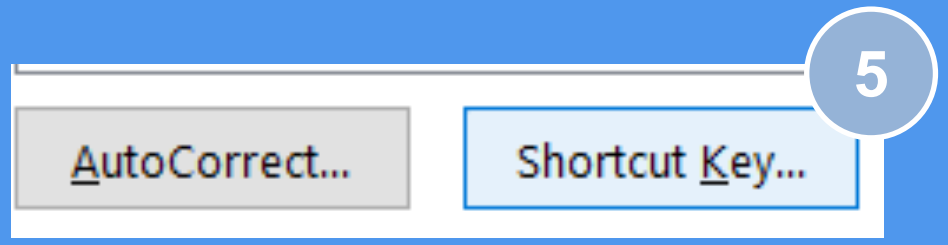
1. Navigate to “Insert” and click “Symbol”
2. Click “More Symbols” in the dropdown
3. Click “Special Characters”
4. Click the symbol you want (e.g., em-dash)

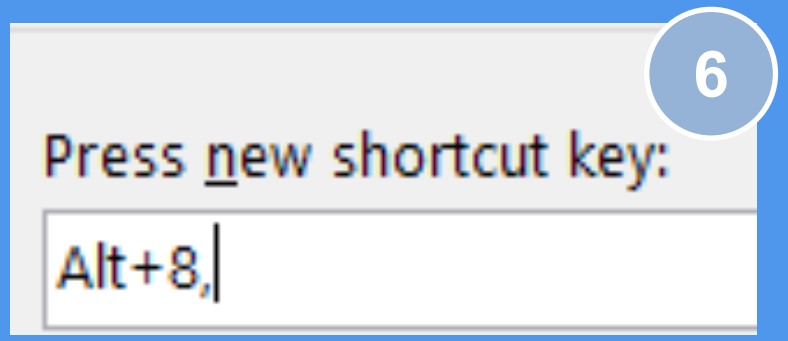


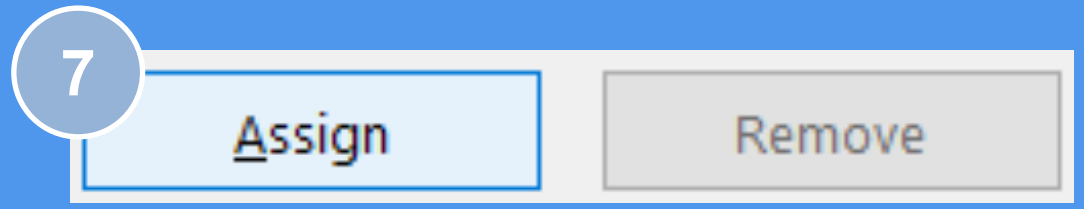


Mapping Symbols to Keys

1. Navigate to “Insert” and click “Symbol”
2. Click “More Symbols” in the dropdown
3. Click “Special Characters”
4. Click the symbol you want (e.g., em-dash)
5. Click “Shortcut Key”
6. In “Press new shortcut key” type in the keys you want to map it to
7. Click “Assign”







Taking the Exam

Preparing Your Computer for the Exam

- Restart your computer before starting the exam to avoid any updates
- Open only the necessary websites and documents:
  - Online *Bluebook*
    - Consider clicking the dropdown on "T1.3: States and the District of Columbia" to make it easier to search for the states during the exam
  - Hyphenation Guide
  - Merriam-Webster Dictionary
  - Any notes you want to access
    - Consider using a paper checklist to minimize the number of windows
  - PDF source file downloaded
  - *Bluebook* exam document downloaded

Review Order on the Exam

There are three popular ways people approach their exam

1. Edit the main text first and then review footnotes
2. Edit the main text and footnotes together as you go along
3. Do all of your checklist items first and then start reading the main text and footnotes

Experiment with these strategies and determine what works best for you

Troubleshooting During the Exam

- There will be editors on call if something goes wrong during the exam (difficulty uploading, technical glitches)
- The *Bluebook* Exam instructions will provide a list of numbers to call
- To avoid technical errors in the document, make sure not to delete call numbers

Familiarizing Yourself with the Exam

- A practice Sourcecite Exam will be released over Spring Break so that you have an opportunity to test out the software
- There will be a short grace period after the exam time ends to submit the documents

Timeline

- The more time you give yourself, the more you'll be able to internalize the *Bluebook*
- That said, some *YLJ* editors did not start studying until Spring Break
- If you're thinking about starting during Spring Break, consider what your other obligations are:
  - Do you have assignments due after Break?
  - Will you be traveling?
- If you're worried about how much time you'll need to study, consider reviewing the slides for one of the rules and doing the corresponding practice exercise. That can help you get a sense of how much time you'll need to study.

Questions?